

The Twenty-Two

Every position on the field, what each one actually does, and why the person wearing the jersey matters less than where he stands and what he's been told to do.

Sunday, a few minutes before kickoff. The broadcast cuts to a graphic: eleven faces, each with a name, a college and two or three letters you only half recognize. *LT. RG. FS. Sam.* Then the game starts and the announcer is talking faster than you can follow: “The nickel is walking down over the slot... the Mike points at the Will... the tight end is the only one in to block...” You know the quarterback. You can probably find the running back. And the other twenty players on the field are, for most viewers, a blur of helmets. This chapter fixes that. By the end, every one of those twenty-two people will have a name, a job and a reason for existing, and you'll know the one distinction that makes the rest of the book possible: the difference between who a player *is*, where he *stands* and what he's been told to *do*.

You'll be able to...

- Name all eleven offensive positions and say what each one does on a run and on a pass.
- Name the defensive positions, from the nose tackle to the free safety, and tell the Mike, Will and Sam linebackers apart by where the tight end lines up.
- Name the special-teams specialists (kicker, punter, long snapper, holder, returner, gunner) and find them on a kicking play.
- Say which offensive players may legally catch a forward pass, and use jersey numbers to check.
- Explain why a guard and a cornerback have such different bodies, using real combine data.
- Separate a player's position from his alignment and his assignment, and explain why good coaches blur all three on purpose.

Twenty-two players, three teams

At any moment eleven players per side are on the field. Not the same eleven, though. An NFL team is really three teams that share a roster: an **offense** for when it has the ball, a **defense** for when the other side has it, and a **special teams** unit for kicking plays (kickoffs, punts, field goals and extra points, which you met in The Game in Fifteen Minutes). A team carries 53 players on its roster, and up to 48 of them dress for a game.¹ Players come and go between plays as freely as the coaches like.

It wasn't always this way, and how it changed explains why NFL bodies look the way they do. For football's first half-century most players played the whole game, offense *and* defense, which meant every player had to be a compromise: big enough to block, quick enough to cover, fit enough to last sixty minutes. Substitution rules were strict, so a player who came out often couldn't go back in that quarter. The NFL loosened them during the Second World War, when rosters were thin, and made **unlimited free substitution** permanent in January 1950.² Within a few years teams were using separate offensive and defensive units (“two platoons”), and then specialists for kicking. The last great player who refused to come off the field was the Eagles' Chuck Bednarik, a center on offense and a linebacker on defense, who played almost all of the 1960 championship game and ended it by tackling the Packers' Jim Taylor on the final play.³

Once a player only had to do one job, he could be built for that job. That is the single biggest reason a modern roster contains 330-pound men who can't run a fast 40 and 190-pound men who can't block anyone: each was chosen for a narrow, demanding task. We'll measure that with real data later in the chapter.

The whole picture first

Here are all twenty-two at once, in a traditional alignment: an offense with two backs behind the quarterback against a classic “base” defense (four linemen, three linebackers, four defensive backs). You'll rarely see this exact picture on a modern Sunday (we'll see the more common one shortly), but it's the clearest way to meet every position, because each one is in its classic spot.

¹NFL roster rules: 53 players on the active roster; on game day 47 players may dress, or 48 if at least eight are offensive linemen, plus an emergency third quarterback under conditions. The 48-man game-day limit (with at least eight offensive linemen; otherwise 47) came in with the 2020 collective bargaining agreement, which runs through the 2030 season: NFL Football Operations, “2020 NFL-NFLPA CBA: Need to know,” <https://operations.nfl.com/inside-football-ops/players-legends/2020-nfl-nflpa-cba-need-to-know>

²Pro Football Hall of Fame, “1950” (football history timeline): the NFL adopted unlimited free substitution permanently on January 20, 1950, opening the way to two-platoon football: <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1940-1959/1950>

³ESPN Classic, “Bednarik was a ‘Sixty-Minute Man’”: https://www.espn.com/classic/biography/s/Bednarik_Chuck.html (Bednarik played center and linebacker for the 1960 champion Eagles and made the final tackle of the championship game on Jim Taylor; inducted into the Hall of Fame in 1967).

How to read the field diagrams in this book. The offense moves up the page. The blue line across the field is the line of scrimmage, the imaginary line through the ball that neither side may cross before the snap (defined fully in Downs, Distance, and Field Position); the thick yellow-orange line is the line to gain, ten yards ahead here. Offensive players are blue circles, defenders are orange squares, and each wears a short tag: **Q** quarterback, **T** or **R** the running back, **F** fullback, **X**, **Z** and **H** wide receivers, **Y** (and sometimes **U**) tight ends, and **LT LG C RG RT** the offensive linemen from left to right (later diagrams often leave the linemen's tags off). On defense, **E** defensive end, **T** defensive tackle, **N** nose tackle, **S M W** the Sam, Mike and Will linebackers, **C** cornerback, **\$** the slot cornerback, **FS** and **SS** the free and strong safeties. A colored ring marks a player to watch.

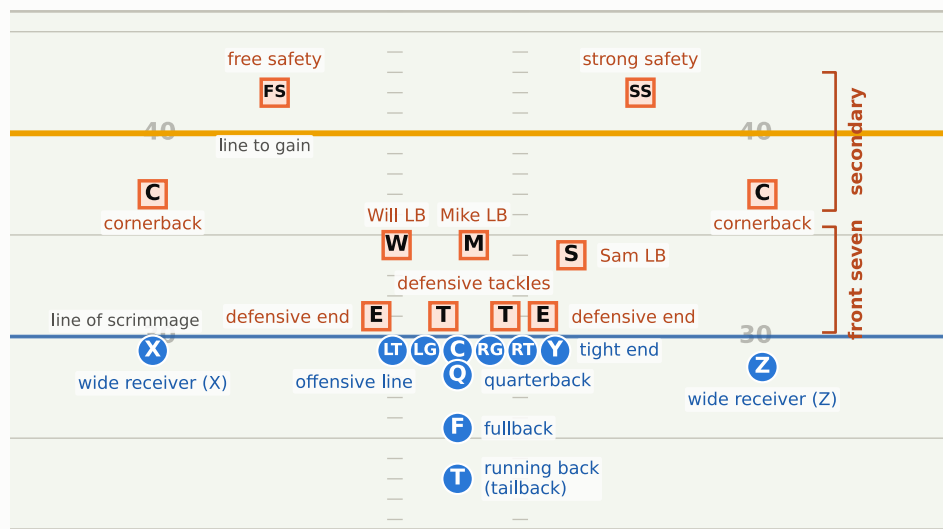


Figure 1: All twenty-two, in a traditional matchup: an offense with two backs stacked behind the quarterback (the I-formation, with a fullback and a tailback) and one tight end, against a base 4-3 defense (four linemen, three linebackers, two cornerbacks and two safeties). The tight end is on the offense's right, so that is the 'strong' side: the Sam linebacker and the strong safety line up there.

Take a moment with that picture before we go player by player. A few patterns are already visible:

- **The middle is crowded and heavy; the edges are open and light.** Ten big men (five offensive linemen, four defensive linemen, plus a tight end) are packed into about twelve yards of width around the ball. The fastest, lightest players (receivers and cornerbacks) are out near the sidelines.
- **The offense is lined up in rows by depth.** Seven players on the line of scrimmage, then the backs behind. That's not a style choice; it's a rule, and it decides who can catch a pass. We'll get to it.
- **The defense is lined up in layers.** Linemen within a yard of the ball, linebackers four or five yards back, cornerbacks out wide about seven yards off, safeties deepest of all. The closer a defender is to the ball, the more he's built to stop the run; the farther away, the more he's built to stop the pass.

The offensive line: five men who never touch the ball

Start in the middle, because every play does. The **offensive line** is the five players shoulder-to-shoulder around the ball: a center, two guards and two tackles. On every snap, run or pass, their job is to block. They almost never touch the ball (the center touches it once, at the snap), they're almost never mentioned on the broadcast unless something goes wrong, and they decide more games than anyone except the quarterback.

From the inside out:

- The **center (C)** is in the middle. He starts every play by **snapping** the ball, handing or tossing it back between his legs (What a Play Really Is covers the snap), and then becomes a blocker like the others, often against the biggest defender on the field, with his head still coming up from the snap. Before the snap he's usually the line's communicator: he identifies which defender the blocking scheme will count from and calls it out, so all five linemen block the same picture. (Pass Protection explains that call, the "Mike ID.")
- The two **guards (LG, RG)** line up on either side of the center. They are often the most powerful linemen, built for short, violent collisions with defensive tackles in a phone booth of space. On some runs a guard **pulls**: steps back off the line at the snap and

runs sideways behind it to block on the other side, which is why guards tend to be a bit quicker than you'd expect (The Language of the Run Game).

- The two **tackles (LT, RT)** are on the outside of the line. Tackles are usually the tallest linemen with the longest arms, because their hardest job is pass protection against the fastest defenders on the field: speed rushers coming from outside, running a wide arc toward the quarterback. A tackle has to slide backward and sideways fast enough to stay in front of a man forty pounds lighter.

Why so big? Because blocking is mostly physics. A blocker's job is to move a defender off a spot, or to keep the defender from moving him off his, and mass and leverage win those contests. Offensive linemen at the NFL Scouting Combine (the league's annual pre-draft testing event, which Building a Roster covers) average a little over 310 pounds and about 6-foot-5.⁴ What they give up is speed: a typical lineman runs 40 yards in a bit over 5.2 seconds, which is very fast for a 310-pound person and slower than nearly everyone else on the field.

 Common misconception: the left tackle is always the best lineman

For decades the left tackle was the glamour job on the line, and for a good reason. Most quarterbacks are right-handed, so when they set up to throw they face right and their back is to the left: the **blind side**. A defender coming free from the left arrives unseen. Michael Lewis built *The Blind Side* (2006) around this: the book opens with the Giants' Lawrence Taylor, the edge rusher who reshaped the position in the 1980s, breaking Joe Theismann's leg from the quarterback's blind side on *Monday Night Football* in 1985, and traces how that kind of threat drove left-tackle salaries up.⁵

That logic still exists, but it's weaker than it was. Modern defenses move their best pass rusher to whichever side they like, often snap to snap; left-handed quarterbacks flip the whole thing; and the right tackle usually faces more run-blocking in front of the tight end. The best tackle in football can play on the right. The Lions drafted **Penei Sewell** seventh overall in 2021, played him at right tackle, and in April 2024 made him, at the time, the highest-paid offensive lineman in the NFL on a four-year, \$112 million extension.⁶ Judge a lineman by how often you *don't* hear about him.

The offensive line has one more defining feature, the one that matters most to you as a viewer: **these five may not catch a forward pass** (more on that soon). And they wear numbers in the 50s, 60s and 70s, so you can always find them.

The quarterback

The **quarterback (Q)** lines up directly behind the center, either with his hands under the center's backside to take a hand-to-hand snap (**under center**) or standing about five yards back to take a short toss (the **shotgun**; both alignments are covered in Formation Rules and the Language of Alignment). He touches the ball on almost every offensive play: he hands it off, fakes a handoff, throws it, or runs with it.

You know the quarterback already, so here's what you might not. His most important work often happens *before* the snap. He usually receives the play call through the radio in his helmet and repeats it to the others (What a Play Really Is). At the line he reads the defense and may change the protection or the whole play. After the snap, on a pass, he isn't just "finding the open man": he's following a planned order of receivers while three-hundred-pound men close in, usually releasing the ball in under three seconds. That's why quarterbacks are the most expensive players in the sport, and why the body type is the least uniform on the field: from 5-foot-10 scramblers to 6-foot-6 pocket passers, what makes a quarterback is mostly invisible (processing speed, accuracy, nerve).

The backs: running back and fullback

Behind (or beside) the quarterback are the **backs**. The names are fossils, inherited from rugby, where the backs stood in rows by depth: quarter-backs nearest the scrimmage, half-backs behind them, a full-back deepest. (You'll often read that the fractions measured literal distances, a quarter, half or all of the way back. That's too neat; the fractions worked more like "first, second and

⁴Averages in this chapter come from the nflverse combine data (`nflreadpy.load_combine()`, sourced from Pro Football Reference), 2010–2026 combines, grouped as in the chart: offensive linemen average about 313 lb and 6-foot-5 with a median 40 of 5.21 s; see the chart for every position.

⁵Michael Lewis, *The Blind Side: Evolution of a Game* (W. W. Norton, 2006). The opening chapter describes Lawrence Taylor's sack of Joe Theismann on November 18, 1985.

⁶Associated Press via Yahoo Sports, "Lions, Penei Sewell reportedly agree to 4-year, \$112M deal that makes him highest-paid OT in NFL" (April 2024): <https://au.sports.yahoo.com/lions-penei-sewell-reportedly-agree-to-4-year-112m-deal-that-makes-him-highest-paid-ot-in-nfl-182233921.html>

last row.”)⁷ The formations changed and the names stuck, which is why today’s fullback lines up *in front of* today’s halfback.

The **running back** (**R**, or **T** for “tailback” when he’s the deepest back), also called the **halfback**, is the offense’s main ball carrier on running plays. Most offenses use one at a time. He takes handoffs and finds the hole, catches short passes (often as the last option, the “checkdown”), and on passing plays he frequently stays in to block a blitzing linebacker before slipping out. Running backs are among the shortest players on the field (about 5-foot-10 on average) but heavy for their height, around 210 pounds: low center of gravity, thick legs, hard to knock over, quick enough to make a defender miss in a small space.

The **fullback** (**F**) is a bigger back, built to block. In the classic two-back offense he lines up between the quarterback and the tailback and leads into the hole ahead of the runner, hitting the first linebacker who shows up. He carries the ball occasionally (often on short-yardage plunges) and catches the odd pass.

You see fewer fullbacks than your parents did. As offenses spread out with three and four receivers, the second back was the obvious player to remove, and many NFL teams now carry no true fullback at all. The ones who remain tend to be unusually versatile, because a player who can only lead-block is hard to justify on a 53-man roster.

i Film room: 49ers 2017–2025 — the fullback who outlived his position

Kyle Juszczyk signed with San Francisco in 2017, when Kyle Shanahan became head coach, and was still there in 2026, his tenth season with the team: a Harvard graduate the Ravens had drafted in the fourth round in 2013, paid like a starter at a position most teams had stopped starting. By the end of the 2025 season he’d been picked for ten straight Pro Bowls, the most ever by a fullback.⁸

Why keep a fullback in the age of the spread? Because Shanahan’s offense is built on the run game and on making the defense guess, and Juszczyk lets one personnel group become many formations. In the same game he lines up as a lead-blocking fullback, as a tight end on the line, as a “wing” just off the tight end’s hip, or split out like a receiver, and he catches passes from all of them. The defense sees two backs on the field and has to keep its bigger, run-stopping players out there, and then the 49ers throw.

The chart below counts how often each offense had two or more backs (running backs plus fullbacks) on the field in 2025. League-wide it’s about one play in ten. The 49ers did it on nearly half their snaps.

What to notice when you watch: before the snap, find the 49ers’ number 44. If he’s behind the quarterback, ask whether he’s going to lead a run or leak out into the flat; if he’s split out wide, watch which defender goes with him.

⁷On the rugby origin and the names as row labels rather than measured depths: “History of American football positions,” https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/History_of_American_football_positions (the fractions “indicate only a form of ordinal number”; the Irish rugby nomenclature used quarter-back, half-back and full-back).

⁸San Francisco 49ers, “Kittle, McCaffrey, Juszczyk, Williams, Gifford, Weeks, Moore selected to 2026 Pro Bowl Games” (December 2025), noting Juszczyk’s 10th Pro Bowl, a record for a fullback: <https://www.49ers.com/news/kittle-mccaffrey-juszczyk-williams-gifford-weeks-moore-selected-to-2026-pro-bowl-games>. The 49ers released and re-signed him on a two-year deal in March 2025 (49ers.com, “49ers Re-Sign FB Kyle Juszczyk to Two-Year Deal”: <https://www.49ers.com/news/49ers-re-sign-fb-kyle-juszczyk-to-two-year-deal>), and he was in their 2026 training camp (49ers.com, “Day 6 of 49ers Camp 2026,” August 3, 2026: <https://www.49ers.com/news/day-6-of-49ers-camp-2026-competition-heats-up-ahead-of-the-preseason>).

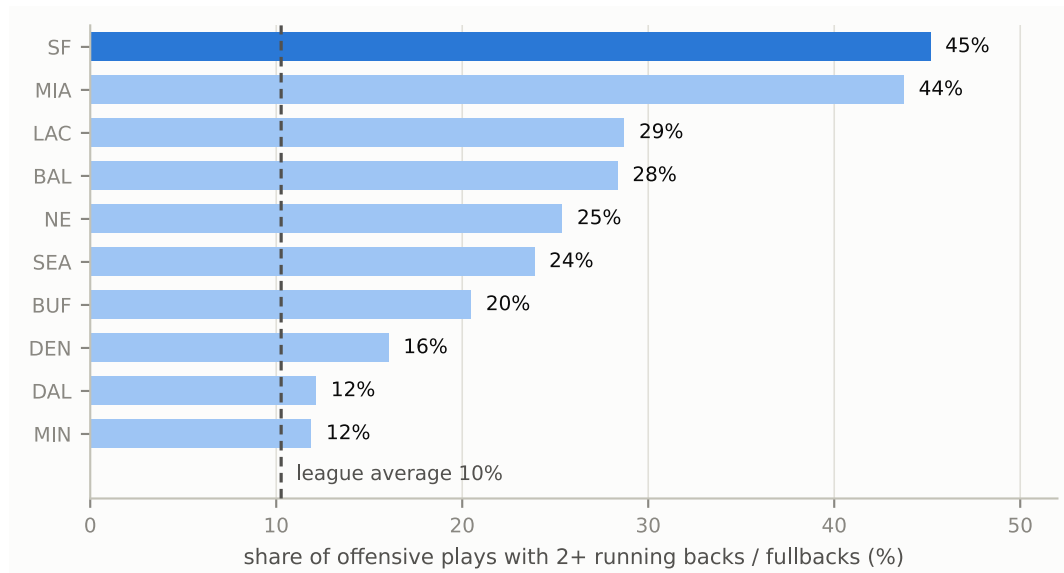


Figure 2: How often each offense had two or more running backs (including fullbacks) on the field, 2025 regular season, run and pass plays. The 49ers and Dolphins, two offenses from the same Kyle Shanahan family tree (Miami's 2025 head coach, Mike McDaniels, came from Shanahan's staff), were far above everyone else. Data: nflverse play-by-play joined to FTN participation charting; the position labels are the players' roster positions.

Wide receivers: X, Z and the slot

The **wide receivers** are the offense's specialist pass-catchers, lined up away from the linemen: "split out" wide near the sideline, or in between, in the area called the **slot**. Their job on a pass is to run a **route** (a planned path, with timing, that you'll learn to read in Passing Game Fundamentals), get open and catch the ball. On a run, they block the defensive backs downfield, a thankless job that turns eight-yard runs into forty-yard ones.

Coaches give each receiver spot a letter, and you'll hear them on broadcasts:

- The **X** receiver lines up on the line of scrimmage, usually on the side away from the tight end. He's often the team's best outside receiver, because being on the line makes him hard to move around and easy for a defender to press at the line, so he needs to be able to beat that.
- The **Z** receiver lines up a yard *off* the line, usually on the tight end's side. Being off the ball gives him a free release and lets him go in motion before the snap.
- The **slot** receiver (often called **H**, or **F**, depending on the team) lines up between the outside receiver and the linemen. Slot receivers work in the middle of the field against linebackers and safeties, so they tend to be quick, sure-handed and good at getting open quickly in traffic rather than outrunning a cornerback over forty yards.

The letters, the rules for being "on" and "off" the line, and the older names (split end for X, flanker for Z) belong to Formation Rules and the Language of Alignment. For now: three letters, three jobs, and the slot is where most of the modern passing game happens.

Receivers are the closest thing football has to sprinters: around 6-foot-1 and 200 pounds on average, with a typical combine 40 of about 4.5 seconds.

The tight end: half lineman, half receiver

The **tight end** (**Y**) is the most interesting position on the offense, because he's two positions at once. In the classic alignment he lines up on the line of scrimmage right next to a tackle, "tight" to the line, as opposed to a split end out wide. From there he can do either of two very different jobs: block a defensive end or linebacker like a sixth lineman, or release into a route like a receiver.

That's exactly why he matters to the defense. When a wide receiver comes on the field, the defense can count on a pass threat; when an extra lineman comes on, it can count on a run. A tight end who can do both forces the defense to defend both. Bodies show it: tight ends average about 6-foot-4 and 250 pounds, between a lineman and a receiver, and run a 40 in about 4.7 seconds, slower than a receiver but much faster than the linebacker who might cover him in size terms.

The side the tight end lines up on is so important that it has a name, the **strong side** of the formation (the other is the weak side; both are formalized in Formation Rules). As you'll see in a moment, several defensive positions are *named* for which side of the tight end they line up on.

Travis Kelce of the Chiefs, a third-round pick in 2013, is the tight end of his era. He had seven straight 1,000-yard receiving seasons from 2016 to 2022, a record for a tight end (no other tight end had more than four 1,000-yard seasons at the time).⁹ Watch him and you'll see the position's whole point: on one snap he's in-line blocking a defensive end, on the next he's split out alone, and the defense has to decide who covers a 255-pounder who runs routes like a receiver.

His older brother, **Jason Kelce**, was the Eagles' center from 2011 to 2023, which makes the Kelces a nice demonstration of this chapter's theme: two brothers, one family's genes, two completely different jobs. At the combine Travis weighed 255 pounds and Jason, an undersized center, 280. In Super Bowl LVII (February 2023) they played against each other: the Chiefs beat the Eagles 38–35.¹⁰

Skill positions, eligible receivers and who may catch a pass

Football broadcasters and fantasy players talk about the **skill positions**: quarterback, running back, wide receiver and tight end, the players who handle the ball. (It's a slightly insulting name, as any offensive lineman will tell you, because blocking is a skill too.) The skill positions overlap closely with a rule that matters a great deal to the strategy of the game: not everyone on the offense is allowed to catch a forward pass.

The rules start with how the offense must line up:¹¹

1. **At least seven players must be on the line of scrimmage** at the snap. So at most four are behind it, in the backfield.
2. Of the players on the line, **only the two on the ends** are **eligible receivers**, allowed to catch a forward pass.
3. **Every player in the backfield is eligible**, with one exception: a quarterback who takes the snap hand-to-hand under center. (A quarterback in the shotgun is just another back and may catch a pass, which is what makes trick plays like the throwback to the quarterback legal.)
4. Everyone else is an **ineligible receiver**: the interior linemen, any player covered up inside the end of the line, and anyone wearing a number from 50 to 79 who hasn't told the referee before the play that he's reporting as eligible.

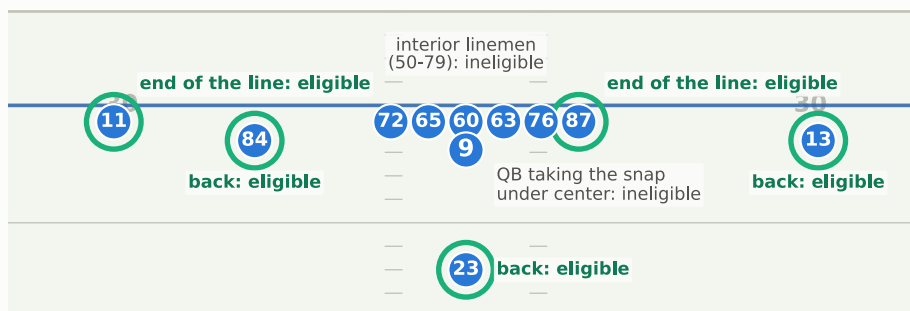


Figure 3: Who may catch a forward pass. Seven players are on the line of scrimmage, four are in the backfield. The two players on the ends of the line (11 and 87) and the backs (84, 13 and 23) are eligible receivers (green rings). The five interior linemen are ineligible, and so is the quarterback, because he's taking the snap under center. The numbers are typical of each position: linemen wear 50-79.

Notice something about that picture: the X receiver and the tight end are on the line, and the Z and the slot receiver are a yard behind it. Those one-yard differences aren't style. Every receiver's spot is a choice about who is on the line, and so who is eligible. If the Z had stepped up onto the line outside the tight end, the tight end would no longer be at the end of the line; he'd be "covered,"

⁹Kansas City Chiefs, "Travis Kelce makes history in Chiefs' win over Denver" (December 2022): <https://www.chiefs.com/news/travis-kelce-makes-history-in-chiefs-win-over-denver>; see also https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Travis_Kelce

¹⁰Super Bowl LVII, February 12, 2023, State Farm Stadium, Glendale, Arizona: Kansas City 38, Philadelphia 35, the first Super Bowl in which two brothers played against each other. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LVII

¹¹NFL Rule 7 (formation: at least seven offensive players on the line at the snap) and Rule 8, Section 1 (eligible receivers, including the T-formation quarterback exception: a quarterback who takes his stance under center is ineligible unless he legally moves at least one yard behind the line, or to the end of the line, and is set for a second before the snap). NFL Football Operations rulebook: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/> ; summarized at https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Eligible_receiver

and ineligible on that play. Offenses use that on purpose, and officials watch for it. (Formation Rules works through covered receivers, tackles who report as eligible, and the trick formations built on both.)

A related rule you'll hear about on run-pass plays: ineligible linemen may not go more than one yard downfield before a forward pass is thrown. That rule, and why it shapes modern offenses, is in Run-Pass Options.

! Why it exists: eligibility

Why restrict who can catch the ball at all? Because without the restriction, the forward pass would swamp the game. If all eleven could go out for a pass, a defense would face eleven potential receivers and nobody guarding the quarterback, and if the big men could catch, an offense could throw to a 320-pounder whom no defensive back could tackle. The eligibility rules keep a balance: the offense must keep seven players on the line, five of them as pure blockers, and announce its receivers by where they stand. That's also why the line-up rules are so fussy. A one-yard step changes who can catch the ball, and the defense has to read it in the seconds before the snap.

Jersey numbers: the uniform as a rulebook

Here's a viewing trick that pays off for the rest of your life: **the number on the jersey tells you the position, roughly, and tells the officials who's eligible.** The NFL has assigned number ranges by position since 1973,¹² and the eligibility rule leans on them: a number is something an official, or a defender, can check at a glance.

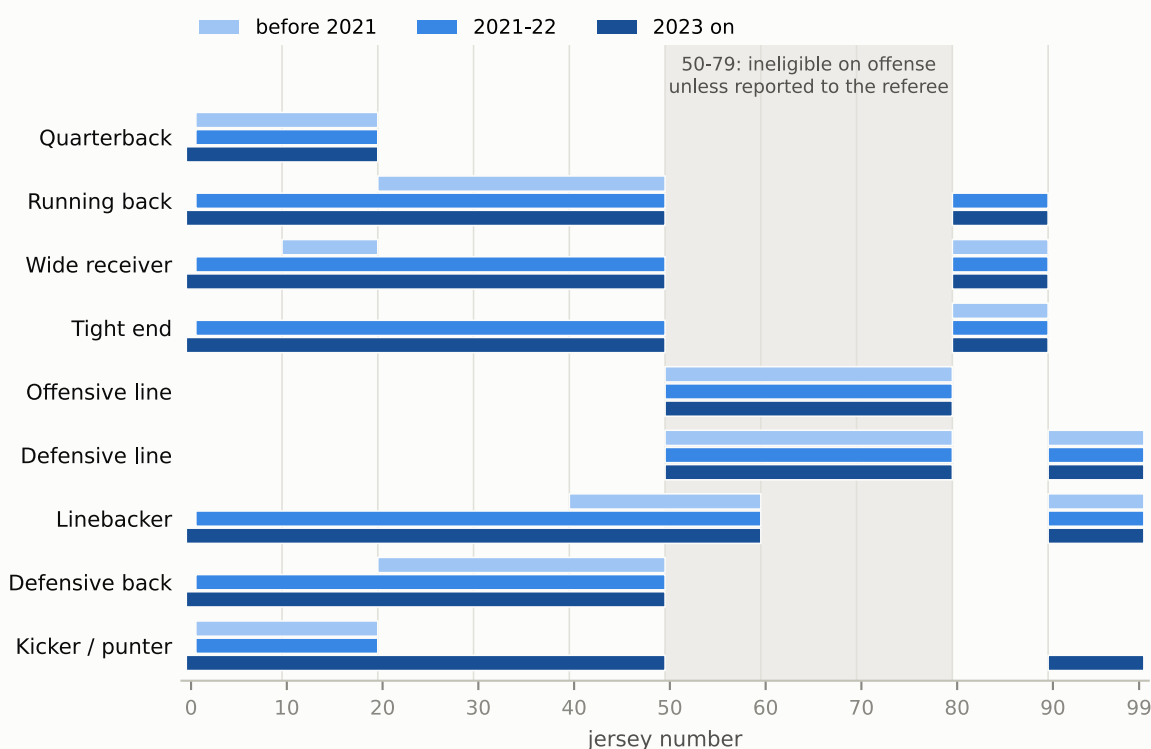


Figure 4: Which numbers each position may wear, before 2021, after the 2021 change and since 2023 (main ranges; under the old system some positions could use a second range when the first was full). The grey band is the ineligible block: on offense, 50-79 means 'I'm a lineman and may not catch a pass unless I report to the referee.' The 2021 and 2023 changes opened single digits and the 0 to almost everyone except linemen, but never touched that band.

The system loosened twice recently. In 2021, owners approved a Kansas City proposal letting running backs, receivers, tight ends, linebackers and defensive backs wear single digits (the Chiefs had run short of numbers in the 20-49 range, four of which

¹²Pro Football Hall of Fame, "1973" (football history timeline): the numbering system was adopted on April 5, 1973 (1-19 quarterbacks and specialists, 20-49 running backs and defensive backs, 50-59 centers and linebackers, 60-79 other linemen, 80-89 receivers and tight ends): <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1960-1979/1973>. The chart's "before 2021" bars show the ranges in force just before 2021, after later loosening: receivers gained 10-19 in 2004 (ESPN, December 5, 2019: https://africa.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/28224466/behind-wide-receivers-numbers-shift-why-nfl-best-donning-nos-10-19), linebackers the 40s in 2015 (NBC Sports/ProFootballTalk: <https://www.nbcsports.com/nfl/profootballtalk/rumor-mill/news/competition-committee-proposes-allowing-lbs-to-wear-jersey-numbers-in-the-40s>), and defensive linemen the 50s around 2010.

the franchise had retired).¹³ In 2023, a Philadelphia proposal added the number 0 for everyone except linemen and let kickers and punters wear 0–49 and 90–99, freeing up single digits for everyone else.¹⁴ So you can no longer tell a running back from a cornerback by number alone; a #1 could be either.

But look at what never changed: **50–79 is still the lineman block**. On offense, a player in that range is ineligible unless he reports. When you see a broadcast cut to the referee announcing “number 70 is reporting as eligible,” the offense is about to use a sixth lineman as a blocking tight end, and the officials are telling the defense, as the rules require. (That substitution has its own story in Formation Rules.)

Numbers are also how you’ll identify players on the field when the broadcast doesn’t help: find the 50s–70s to locate the line, the 90s to find defensive linemen and many edge rushers, and the single digits and 20s–40s out wide to find receivers and defensive backs.

The defense: front seven and secondary

Now turn around. The defense is easiest to understand as two groups, which you saw bracketed in the first diagram:

- The **front seven**: the defensive linemen and the linebackers, the defenders who line up near the ball and play the run first.
- The **secondary**: the cornerbacks and safeties, the “defensive backs,” who line up farther away and are responsible first for the pass.

That split is a trade-off the defense makes on every play. Defenders near the ball are quick to the runner but poorly placed to cover a receiver thirty yards downfield; defenders far away are the reverse. A coordinator’s most basic decision is how many to put near the ball and how many to keep back, a balance called **box count** that A First Look at Defense teaches.

Defensive line: tackles, the nose and ends

The defensive linemen line up within a yard or so of the ball, in a three- or four-point stance (one or two hands on the ground), across from the offensive linemen. Their job is the mirror image of the offensive line’s: on runs, hold their ground, fill their gap (the space between two offensive linemen that the defense assigns them), and shed blocks to make tackles; on passes, get to the quarterback.

- The **defensive tackles (T)** line up inside, across from the guards and center. They are the heaviest defenders (about 6-foot-3 and 310 pounds at the combine), because their first job is to occupy blockers in the middle of the line, often two at once, so the linebackers behind them can run free. A good one also collapses the **pocket** (the protected space the blockers form around the quarterback; see Pass Protection) on passing plays, pushing straight back into the quarterback’s face, which is worse for a quarterback than pressure from the outside because he can’t step up away from it.
- The **nose tackle (N)** is the defensive tackle who lines up on (or nearly on) the center. In a defense with three linemen he’s the one in the middle, head-up on the center, and he’s usually the biggest man on the team. The Eagles’ **Jordan Davis**, a nose tackle drafted in 2022, measured 6-foot-6 and 341 pounds at the combine and then ran the 40 in 4.78 seconds, faster than the typical quarterback.¹⁵
- The **defensive ends (E)** line up on the outside, across from or outside the offensive tackles. They’re lighter and faster than tackles (about 6-foot-4 and 260 pounds), because their two jobs both happen in open space: rush the passer around the edge, and on runs, keep the ball carrier from getting outside them.

Where exactly each lineman lines up (head-up on a guard, shaded on his outside shoulder, and so on) has its own numbering system, the “techniques,” which The Language of the Run Game introduces and Defensive Line Play deepens.

Aaron Donald, who played for the Rams from 2014 until he retired after the 2023 season, is the archetype of a defensive tackle who broke the mold. At 6-foot-1 and about 285 pounds he was small for the position, and teams worried about it before the draft. Then he ran a 4.68 40 at the combine, a time you’d expect from a linebacker. He became the most disruptive interior lineman of his era, three times Defensive Player of the Year.¹⁶ He’s useful to remember for a simple reason: he shows what the “size” norms

¹³CBS Sports, “NFL reportedly passes new jersey number rules: Who can wear what under revised guidelines” (April 2021): <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/nfl-reportedly-passes-new-jersey-number-rules-who-can-wear-what-under-revised-guidelines> ; on the Chiefs’ proposal and its motivation, Sports Illustrated (April 8, 2021): <https://www.si.com/nfl/2021/04/08/nfl-allow-jersey-number-changes-2021-season>

¹⁴CBS Sports, “NFL rule changes 2023: No. 0 jersey is back...” (March 2023): <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/nfl-rule-changes-2023-no-0-jersey-is-back-personal-foul-penalties-clarified-one-date-for-roster-cutdowns> ; NBC Sports Philadelphia, “NFL rule change allows players to wear No. 0” (on the Eagles’ proposal): <https://www.nbcportsphiladelphia.com/nfl/philadelphia-eagles/nfl-rule-change-allows-players-to-wear-no-0/271995/>

¹⁵nflverse combine data, 2022 combine: Jordan Davis (Georgia), 6-6, 341 lb, 40-yard dash 4.78 s; the median quarterback 40 in the chart is about 4.80 s.

¹⁶Pro Football Reference, Aaron Donald: <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/players/D/DonaAa00.htm> (Defensive Player of the Year 2017, 2018, 2020; retired in March 2024). Combine figures (6-1, 285 lb, 4.68 s) from the nflverse combine data.

in this chapter are for. They're not rules, they're the average solutions to a physics problem, and a player who solves the problem differently (with quickness instead of mass) can be better than all of them.

Edge rushers

The **edge rusher** is the modern name for the defender whose main job is getting to the quarterback from outside the offensive tackle. You'll hear "edge" constantly now, and the reason is that the old position names stopped fitting. In a four-man line the edge rusher is called a defensive end and usually puts a hand on the ground. In a three-man line, the edge rushers are called *outside linebackers* and often stand up. Same job, two names, so the league's vocabulary converged on "edge." Even the Scouting Combine created an "EDGE" workout group in 2018 instead of choosing between DE and OLB.¹⁷

Edge rushers are among the most valuable players in football, because pass pressure wrecks offenses and the edge is where the most of it comes from. **T.J. Watt** of the Steelers is the model: technically an outside linebacker, 6-foot-4 and 252 pounds at his combine, he tied the single-season sack record with 22.5 in 2021, and that record stood until Myles Garrett, a 4-3 defensive end in Cleveland, got to 23 in 2025.¹⁸ (Watt's older brother J.J., a 290-pound defensive end at his combine, is another two-brothers, two-bodies example.) How edge rushers win (and why "pressures" matter more than sacks) is the subject of The Pass Rush.

Linebackers: Mike, Will and Sam

The **linebackers** line up behind the defensive line, usually four or five yards off the ball: the "second level" of the defense. They are the defense's all-purpose players. On a run, they read the play and fill the gap the runner is heading for; on a pass, they drop into coverage on the short middle of the field or cover a back or tight end; and sometimes they blitz, rushing the quarterback themselves. Body: about 6-foot-1 and 235 pounds, a compromise between the size to take on a fullback and the speed to cover a running back.

In a defense with three linebackers, each has a one-letter name, and the letters come from where they line up *relative to the offense's tight end*:

- The **Mike linebacker (M)** is the middle linebacker. He's usually the defense's signal-caller (often the one with the radio in his helmet, the "green dot" from What a Play Really Is), and he's the player you see pointing and shouting adjustments before the snap. The 49ers' **Fred Warner**, a third-round pick in 2018, is the modern ideal: a Mike who runs and covers like a safety.
- The **Sam linebacker (S)** is the *strong-side* linebacker: he lines up on the tight end's side. He's usually the biggest and most physical of the three, because he has to take on a tight end's block. He's also usually the first linebacker to leave the field when the offense spreads out, as you'll see in a moment.
- The **Will linebacker (W)** is the *weak-side* linebacker, away from the tight end. With fewer blockers on his side, he's often unblocked at the snap, so the Will tends to be the fastest of the three: a chaser who runs plays down from behind.

Because Sam and Will are named by the tight end's side, **they flip sides when the tight end does**. If the tight end lines up on the left, the Sam goes left. That's one of the first things you can learn to see from your couch: find the tight end, and you know where the Sam is going to be.

Linebackers' jobs (their reads, their keys, why it's "the hardest job on the field") are the subject of Linebackers.

i Madden vs. real life

In a video game, a position is a slot on a depth chart: put a player at "LB" and the game stands him where linebackers go. In real football, the defensive position names are *relational*: the Sam is defined by where the tight end is, so he can be on the left on one play and the right on the next; the "strong safety" is the safety on the strong side, whichever one that is. Many defenses go further and swap names *by alignment* instead of by player: whoever ends up on the strength is the Sam this play. Learn the positions as jobs defined relative to the offense, not as fixed spots on the screen.

The secondary: cornerbacks, the slot corner and safeties

The defensive backs are the lightest, fastest players on the defense, and the last line between a receiver and the end zone.

¹⁷Minnesota Vikings, "2018 Combine Workout Warriors: Edge Rushers" (March 4, 2018), noting that 2018 was "the first year for the positional category": <https://vikings.com/news/2018-combine-workout-warriors-edge-rushers-20415827>. In the nflverse combine data, too, the "EDGE" label first appears for the 2018 class.

¹⁸NFL.com, "Browns DE Myles Garrett reaches 23 sacks, sets new NFL single-season record" (January 2026): <https://www.nfl.com/news/browns-de-myles-garrett-reaches-23-sacks-sets-new-nfl-single-season-record>. The previous record, 22.5, was shared by Michael Strahan (2001) and T.J. Watt (2021).

- The **cornerbacks (C)** line up across from the outside wide receivers, near the sidelines, anywhere from right in the receiver's face ("press") to eight or nine yards off. Their job is pass coverage, either following a receiver wherever he goes (**man coverage**) or guarding an area of the field (**zone**); both are introduced in A First Look at Defense. Corners are smaller than receivers on average (about 5-foot-11 and 190 pounds) and as fast: the typical combine 40 is about 4.5 seconds, tied with receivers for the fastest on the field. The hardest thing in their job is that they must react: the receiver knows where he's going and the corner has to mirror him running backward or sideways.
- The **slot cornerback (\$)**, also called the **nickel back**, covers the slot receiver. He lines up inside, between the outside cornerback and the box, so he's part cornerback and part linebacker: he has to cover quick receivers in the middle of the field *and* tackle runners and blitz off the edge. We'll see where he comes from below.
- The **safeties** line up deepest, usually 10 to 15 yards off the ball: the last line of defense against long passes and long runs. Most defenses have two:
 - the **free safety (FS)**, who usually plays deeper and in the middle, "free" of responsibility for a particular receiver so that he can go wherever the ball goes; and
 - the **strong safety (SS)**, who lines up on the strong (tight end) side, often a bit closer to the line, and helps more against the run.

How many safeties stay deep before the snap (one or two) is the most important single clue you'll learn to read on defense. A First Look at Defense starts that habit, and Coverage Fundamentals builds it out.

The picture you'll actually see: three receivers vs. five defensive backs

The first diagram was the textbook. Here's the more common picture on a modern Sunday: the offense with one running back, one tight end and three wide receivers, against a defense that has taken a linebacker off and put a fifth defensive back on.

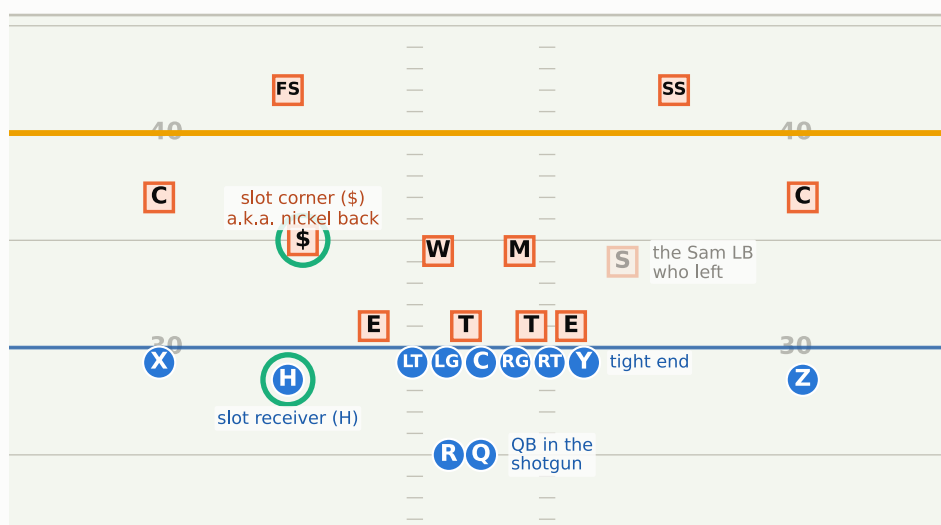


Figure 5: The modern default. The offense has replaced its fullback with a third wide receiver, the slot receiver H, and moved the quarterback back into the shotgun. The defense answers by replacing a linebacker (the Sam, ghosted on the right) with a slot cornerback (\$) who can cover H. Both rings mark the swap: the most common matchup in today's NFL, a slot receiver against a slot corner.

Two substitutions happened there, one on each side, and they're connected. The offense took off its fullback and put on a third receiver. That receiver lines up in the slot, and if the defense left its Sam linebacker in to cover him, it would be matching a 235-pound linebacker against a quick, 190-pound receiver in open space, a matchup offenses hunt for. So the defense takes off the Sam and puts on a fifth defensive back, the slot corner, who can run with him.

That fifth defensive back has a name you'll hear in every broadcast: the defense is in **nickel** (five defensive backs: a nickel is five cents). The offensive grouping has a name too: one back and one tight end is **11 personnel**. Both systems of shorthand get full chapters: Personnel for the offense's numbers and A First Look at Defense for the defense's packages ("base," nickel, dime).

How common is this picture? In 2025, about three NFL plays in five had exactly one back and one tight end on the field, by far the

most common grouping,¹⁹ and defenses were in their “base” package (with three linebackers) on under 30% of plays.²⁰ In practical terms the slot cornerback is a starter on every defense, even though he isn’t one of the eleven on the “base” diagram. If you want to know who the defense’s starting eleven *really* are, count the defensive backs on first-and-10.

Notice also what the defense calls its front now: four linemen and two linebackers make six, not seven. “Front seven” is a habit of language from the base-defense era; in nickel, the safety or the slot corner who lines up near the ball becomes the seventh man in the front on run downs. Defenses fill that seventh spot in different ways, and the choice tells you what they fear.

Special teams: the specialists

The third team gets less airtime but about one snap in six,²¹ and it has positions that exist nowhere else.

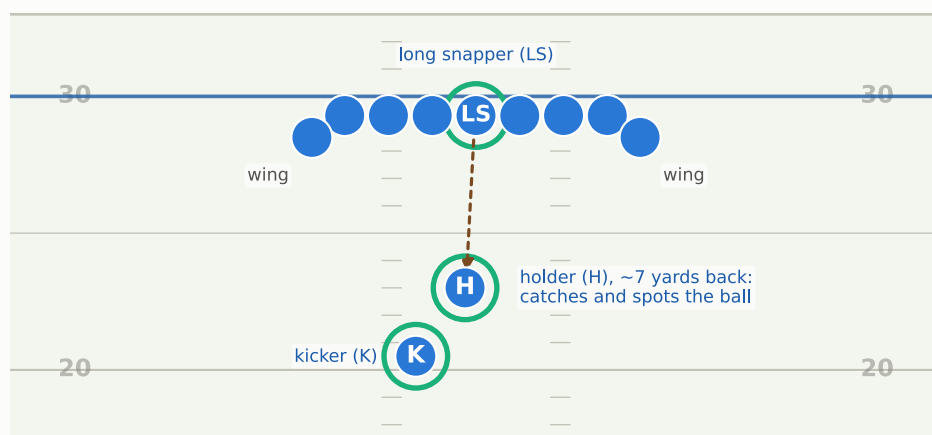


Figure 6: A field-goal unit. Seven men on the line protect the kick: the long snapper in the middle, linemen beside him and two tight ends at the ends, with two ‘wings’ set just behind and outside the ends to stop rushers coming off the edge. The long snapper fires the ball about seven yards back to the holder (the dashed brown line), who spots it for the kicker. The whole operation, snap to kick, takes about 1.3 seconds.

- The **kicker (K)** kicks field goals, extra points and (on most teams) kickoffs. NFL kickers are specialists in the purest sense: they practice one motion and are judged on it in front of 70,000 people.
- The **punter (P)** punts the ball away on fourth down, standing about 15 yards behind the line so that rushers can’t reach him before he kicks. Punters are judged on distance *and* hang time (how long the ball stays in the air), because hang time gives the coverage team time to get downfield.
- The **long snapper (LS)** snaps the ball on punts, field goals and extra points. It sounds trivial and isn’t: he has to fire the ball accurately seven yards to a holder (or fifteen to a punter) in well under a second, with the laces landing where they should, and then block a defender charging at him. On a field goal, the snap, the hold and the kick together are drilled to take about 1.3 seconds.²² Teams keep a dedicated one because a bad snap is the most catastrophic error in the kicking game.
- The **holder** catches the snap on a field goal or extra point and sets the ball on its point for the kicker. On most NFL teams the holder is the punter: he has the best hands for a long snap among the specialists, and he’s on the field anyway.
- The **returner** catches kickoffs and punts and tries to run them back. Returners are usually fast backs, receivers or defensive backs. Kickoffs have changed so much since 2024 that they get their own chapter, Kickoffs, Returns, and the Dynamic Kickoff.
- The **gunner** is the punt team’s missile: one of two players split out wide whose only job is to sprint downfield and tackle the returner. The return team answers by putting one or two blockers on each gunner, called **vices** or jammers (Field Goals, Extra Points, and the Punting Game), to hold him up at the line.

¹⁹nflverse play-by-play and participation data, 2025 regular season, run and pass plays: 11 personnel (one back, one tight end) on 58.8% of plays, its lowest share of the decade (planning calculation recorded in this book’s fact sheet; reproduced in Personnel).

²⁰NFL Next Gen Stats via NFL.com, “NFL trend watch: Heavy personnel could shape Super Bowl LX showdown between Patriots and Seahawks”: defenses played base on 29.7% of plays in 2025, up from a low of 20.5% in 2023. <https://www.nfl.com/news/nfl-trend-watch-heavy-personnel-could-shape-super-bowl-lx-showdown-between-patriots-and-seahawks>

²¹Kickoffs, punts, field goals and extra points were 17.5% of 2025 regular-season plays (course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, documented in What a Play Really Is).

²²Justin Tucker in *Baltimore* magazine (September 2014), “this 1.3-second field-goal operation, from the snap to the hold to the kick”: <https://www.baltimoremagazine.com/2014/9/5/justin-tucker-renaissance-raven> ; Kicking System (2012) gives 1.2–1.35 s as the professional range: <https://kickingssystem.com/2012/08/15/special-teams-unit-field-goals-operation-times-working-with-the-snapper-and-holder/>

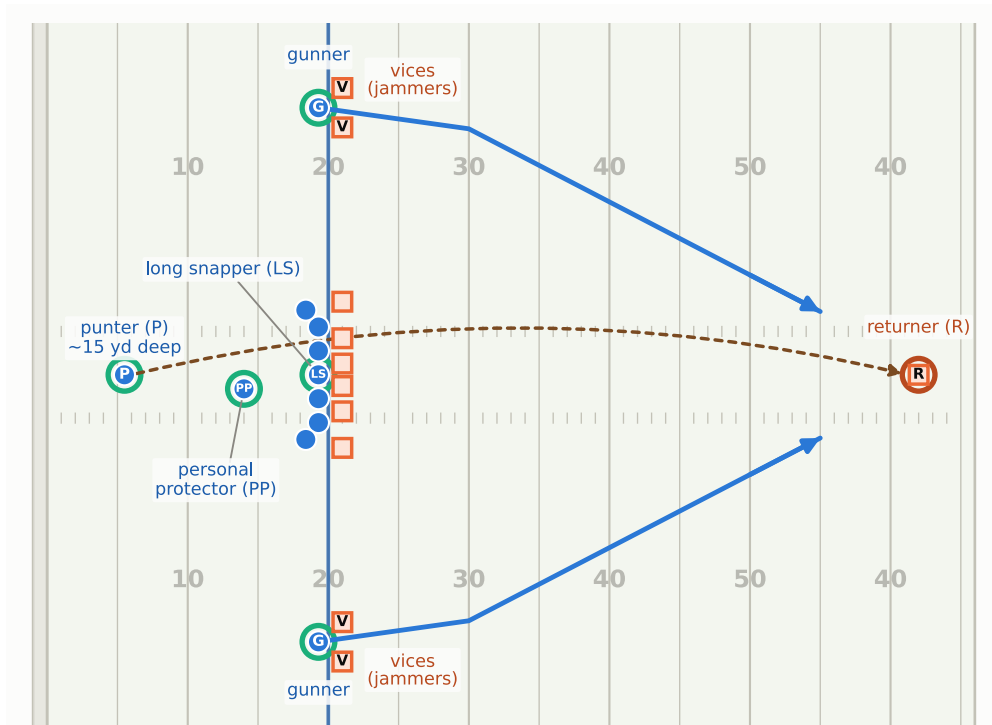


Figure 7: A punt, seen from the side with the punting team kicking left to right. The long snapper fires the ball about 15 yards to the punter; the personal protector stands between them to pick up any rusher who gets through. The two gunners, out wide on the line, release past the vices (V) trying to jam them and race downfield toward the returner (R), who will catch the ball 40-odd yards away. The dashed brown arc is the punt.

The rest of the special-teams units are made of regular position players, mostly backups: linebackers, safeties, tight ends and running backs, the players with a mix of size, speed and tackling ability. Coverage units are where a lot of young players earn their roster spot, and a few make a career of it. The Patriots' **Matthew Slater**, a gunner who played for New England from 2008 to 2023, made ten Pro Bowls as a special-teams player, the most ever for a special teamer (Steve Tasker is next with seven).²³

Why bodies match jobs

You've now heard a lot of heights and weights. Here they all are, from seventeen years of the NFL Scouting Combine: every prospect measured from 2010 to 2026, one dot each, with each position's average marked.

²³NFL.com, "Patriots' 10-time Pro Bowl special teamer Matthew Slater announces retirement" (February 2024): <https://nfl.com/news/patriots-10-time-pro-bowl-special-teamer-matthew-slater-announces-retirement> ; the record and Tasker's seven: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Matthew_Slater



Figure 8: Size and speed by position, NFL Scouting Combine 2010-2026 (one faint dot per prospect; the big dot is each position's average weight and height, or median 40 time). Top: the positions sort into families by size, from cornerbacks and receivers around 190-200 lb to linemen past 300. Bottom: weight and speed trade off along almost a straight line. Ambiguous labels are left out: generic 'DL', 'DB' and 'OLB' (which mixed 3-4 edge rushers with 4-3 linebackers). Edge = DE or EDGE. Data: nflverse combine data, from Pro Football Reference.

Read the top panel from left to right and it sorts the field into families:

- **The speed family** (left, 190–215 lb): cornerbacks, wide receivers, safeties, running backs, and, interestingly, kickers, who are built like defensive backs.
- **The hybrids** (middle, 220–265 lb): quarterbacks, linebackers, fullbacks, tight ends and edge rushers, plus the long snappers. These are the positions whose jobs mix contact with space: a linebacker has to take on a fullback *and* cover a back; a tight end has to block an end *and* outrun a linebacker.
- **The big men** (right, 300+ lb): offensive linemen and defensive tackles, almost indistinguishable from each other in size, because they spend every snap pushing against each other.

The bottom panel shows the price of mass: weight and 40 time fall along nearly a straight line. Each extra 20 pounds costs roughly a tenth of a second over 40 yards, and the positions sit along that line wherever their job puts the balance between force and speed.

Edge rushers sit just above the line (fast for their size), which is why they're so hard to block; Aaron Donald sits *far* above it, which is why he was Aaron Donald.

Why does this matter to a viewer? Because body type is how you'll recognize positions when the alignment is ambiguous, and how you'll spot the mismatches offenses and defenses hunt for. A 250-pound tight end covered by a 190-pound cornerback is a mismatch in one direction (the tight end can shield the ball with his body); the same tight end covered by a 240-pound linebacker is a mismatch in the other (the tight end is faster). Half of play-calling is creating one of those pictures and the other half is avoiding them. And the size bands explain one of the oldest jokes in football analysis: "he's a tweener," a player whose body sits between two families and doesn't clearly fit either job. Some tweeners never find a role; others (Kyle Hamilton, below) become the most valuable players on their team because they can do both jobs.

How much each position is *worth*, in salary and draft picks, is a separate and fascinating question for Building a Roster.

Position, alignment, assignment

Everything so far has treated a position as if it told you what a player does. It doesn't, quite. To read a play, you have to separate three different things:

- **Position** is who the player *is*: what the roster says, what he's built for, which meeting room he sits in during the week. Kyle Hamilton is a safety.
- **Alignment** is where he *lines up* on this play: his spot, depth and relation to the ball and the other players. Hamilton might be 12 yards deep, over the slot receiver, or standing in the box beside the linebackers.
- **Assignment** is what he's been told to *do* on this play: which gap he fills, which receiver or area he covers, whether he rushes. From any of those alignments, Hamilton might blitz, cover the tight end man-to-man, or drop into a deep half of the field.

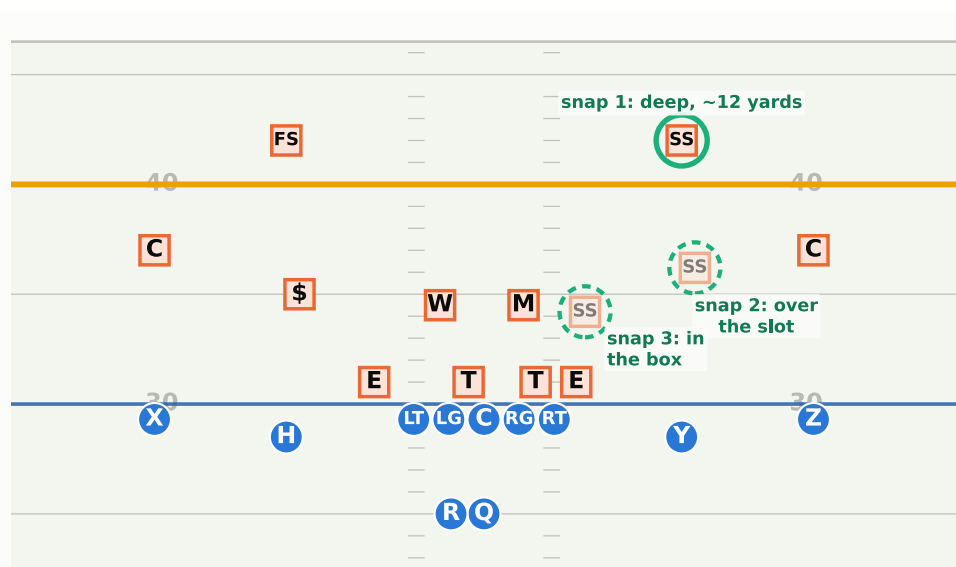


Figure 9: One position, three alignments. The same strong safety (ringed) on three different snaps against the same offensive formation: deep, about 12 yards off the ball (snap 1, solid); walked down over the slot receiver (snap 2); and in the box beside the linebackers (snap 3). His position never changes. His alignment does, and his assignment on each snap could be any of several things. Alignment is a clue to the assignment, not a guarantee.

Why does the difference matter? Because **football is a game of disguise and recognition**, and the gap between these three is where the disguise lives. A defense that lines a safety up deep and *then* sends him on a blitz has used alignment to hide assignment. An offense that lines its running back up as a wide receiver is forcing the defense to decide: do we cover him with a linebacker (who's good against running backs) or a cornerback (who's good against receivers)? Everything in this book about reading the game comes down to using alignment to guess assignment before the snap, and then checking yourself after it.

It's also why rosters are more fluid than position labels suggest:

- The 49ers' **Deebo Samuel**, a wide receiver, was lined up in the backfield and handed the ball so often in 2021 that he called himself a "wide back"; his eight rushing touchdowns that season were the most by a receiver since 1970.²⁴
- Juszczak, the film-room fullback, spends much of his time lined up as a tight end or a receiver.

- Most defenses list a “linebacker” who plays almost every down as a fifth defensive back, or a “safety” who plays almost every down near the line, and teams increasingly don’t care what the roster calls him.

Even the official data struggles with this. The participation data behind the two-backs chart above lists each player by his *roster* position, so a center who started a game at guard is still counted as a center. When you meet personnel data in Personnel, remember that it records who’s on the field, not where they stood.

i Film room: Ravens 2022–2025 — Kyle Hamilton, one position, every alignment

The Ravens drafted **Kyle Hamilton** 14th overall in 2022.²⁵ He’s a safety, and an unusual one: 6-foot-4 and 220 pounds at his combine, a height only about one safety in forty measured there since 2010 has matched, built more like a big receiver or a small linebacker. Some evaluators worried about where he’d fit.

Baltimore’s answer was: everywhere. Watch the Ravens’ defense and find number 14 before every snap. On one play he’s a deep safety; on the next he’s lined up over the slot like a nickel back; on the next he’s in the box beside the linebackers, or walked up on the line over a tight end. He blitzes, covers tight ends man-to-man, and plays deep zones, so an offense can’t tell from his position what he’s about to do, and has trouble telling from his alignment. That flexibility is the whole value: one player who can be a safety, a slot corner and a linebacker lets the defense change its shape without changing its personnel, which means the offense can’t use substitutions to force a mismatch. It has made him a first-team All-Pro twice, for 2023 and 2025.²⁶

What to notice: before the snap, where is 14, and does he move? If he starts deep and creeps down late, something is coming; if he starts in the box and bails to the deep middle at the snap, the defense just changed its coverage shell on you. You’ll learn to name those moves in Disguise, Rotation, and Split-Field Coverage.

One ordinary run, all twenty-two

To see every position doing its job at once, here’s one simple, old-fashioned running play from the first diagram: the fullback leads through the gap between the left guard and left tackle, and the tailback follows him. Each player has one assignment, and each assignment is typical of his position.

²⁴ESPN, “How Deebo Samuel created his own position: ‘wide back’” (2022): https://africa.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/33089904/san-francisco-49ers-deebo-samuel-created-own-position-wide-back (eight rushing touchdowns in 2021, the most by a receiver in a season since 1970).

²⁵Pro Football Reference, 2022 NFL Draft (Baltimore, 14th overall: Kyle Hamilton, S, Notre Dame): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/years/2022/draft.htm> ; combine figures (6-4, 220 lb) from the nflverse combine data, in which about 2.4% of safeties measured 2010–2026 were 6-foot-4 or taller.

²⁶*The Baltimore Banner*, on the 2025 All-Pro team (January 10, 2026): Hamilton’s third All-Pro selection and second on the first team (46 of 50 first-team votes), after first team for 2023 and second team for 2024: <https://www.thebanner.com/sports/ravens-nfl/ravens-all-pro-team-kyle-hamilton-jordan-stout-ricard-XTMJAR4HXRDQPOFJCHLCHIIG34>

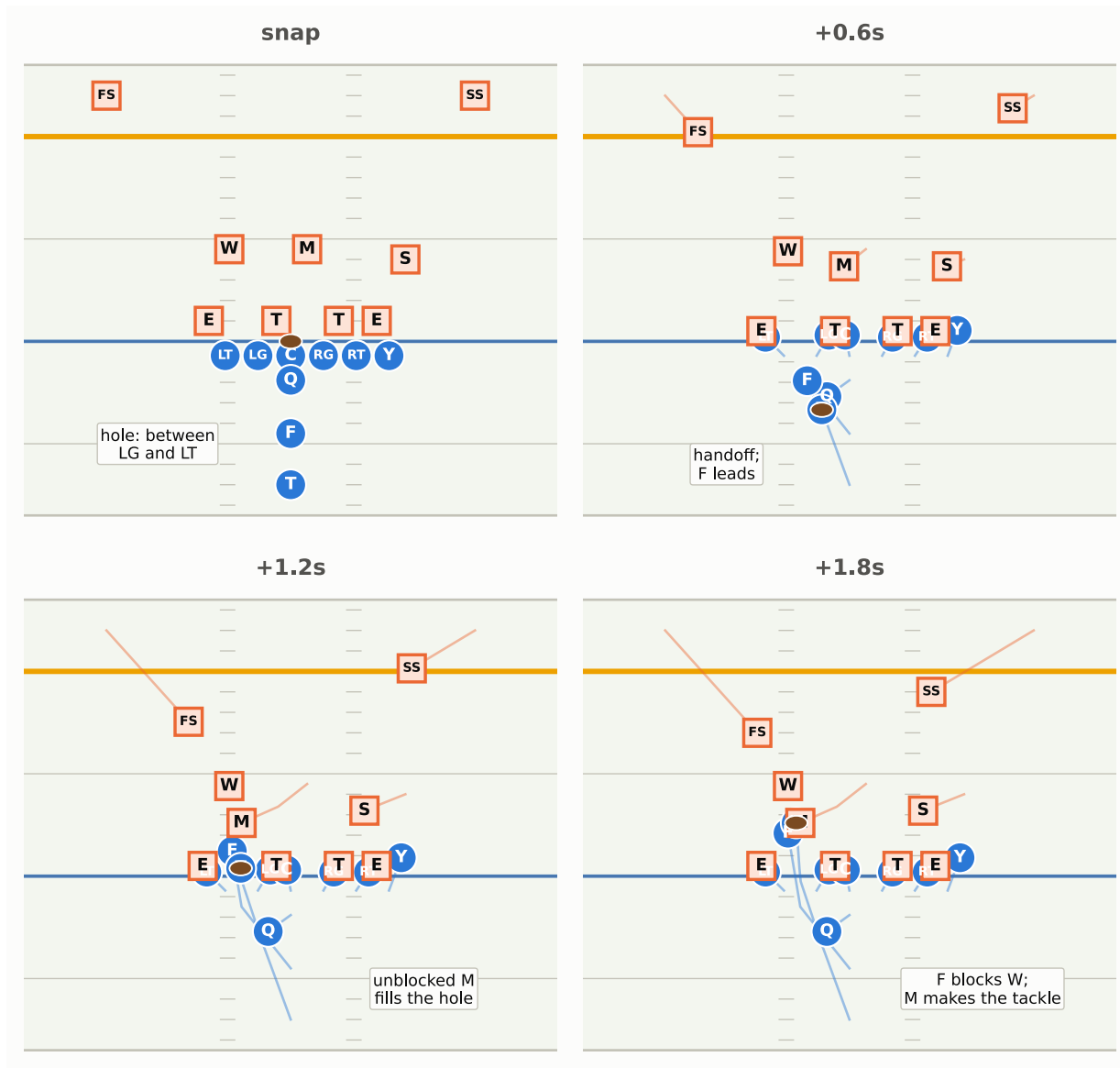


Figure 10: A lead run from the I-formation against a base 4-3, in seconds after the snap. The linemen block the defensive linemen in front of them (the left guard and center double-team the tackle shaded over the center; the left tackle drives the end outward), which opens a hole between the left guard and left tackle. The quarterback opens and hands off; the fullback (F) leads through the hole onto the Will linebacker; the tight end and receivers block. The one defender nobody blocks is the Mike linebacker, who fills the hole and meets the tailback. The safeties come down to help. In print, the zoom shows the box; the receivers and cornerbacks are blocking out wide.

Go through it one position at a time, the way you'll learn to watch a replay:

- **Offensive line:** each lineman blocks the man in front of him or helps a neighbor. Nobody on the line blocks a linebacker on this play; that's the fullback's job.
- **Quarterback:** opens, hands off, and (on a real play) carries out a fake so a defender has to think about him for half a second.
- **Fullback:** leads into the hole and blocks the first linebacker who shows (here, the Will).
- **Tailback:** takes the handoff, follows the fullback and reads his block.
- **Tight end and receivers:** block. The receivers' blocks on the cornerbacks are what turn a five-yard gain into a long one if the runner breaks a tackle.
- **Defensive linemen:** take on their blockers and try not to get moved.
- **Linebackers:** read the run and fill. The Will takes on the fullback; the Mike, untouched, arrives in the hole.
- **Safeties:** read run and come down to the line, the last line of defense if the Mike misses.
- **Cornerbacks:** play their receivers until they're sure it's a run.

Notice that the play is a contest over one defender. The offense has eleven players and the defense eleven, but the quarterback and tailback don't block, so the offense can't block everyone; it chooses whom to leave alone. Here it left the Mike, and the play works only if the tailback beats him. Which defender the offense chooses *not* to block, and how it makes that man wrong, is a theme that runs through the whole run game (The Language of the Run Game) and turns into option football in Option Football.

💡 Watch for it on Sunday: the one-player game

For one full drive, **watch only the center**. Ignore the ball. On every snap, say out loud what he did:

- **Before the snap:** does he point at a defender or shout something? (He's naming the defender the blocking scheme counts from.) Does the quarterback point first and the center echo him, or the other way round?
- **At the snap:** under center or shotgun? A shotgun snap is a five-yard toss; watch whether the center's head comes up fast.
- **After the snap:** did he block the man over him, help a guard with a double-team, step to a linebacker, or (on a screen pass) release downfield to block in space? Did he ever touch the ball again? (He shouldn't.)

Then, if you have time for more:

- **Count the defensive backs** on first-and-10. Four means a base defense; five means a slot cornerback is on the field.
- **Find the tight end before the snap** and predict which side the Sam linebacker and the strong safety will line up on.
- **On a punt, find the gunners** before the snap and count how many defenders the return team puts on each: one or two?
- **Check a jersey.** When a player in the 50s–70s lines up somewhere unusual (out at tight end, in the backfield), listen for the referee's announcement that he's reporting as eligible.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: name the linebackers

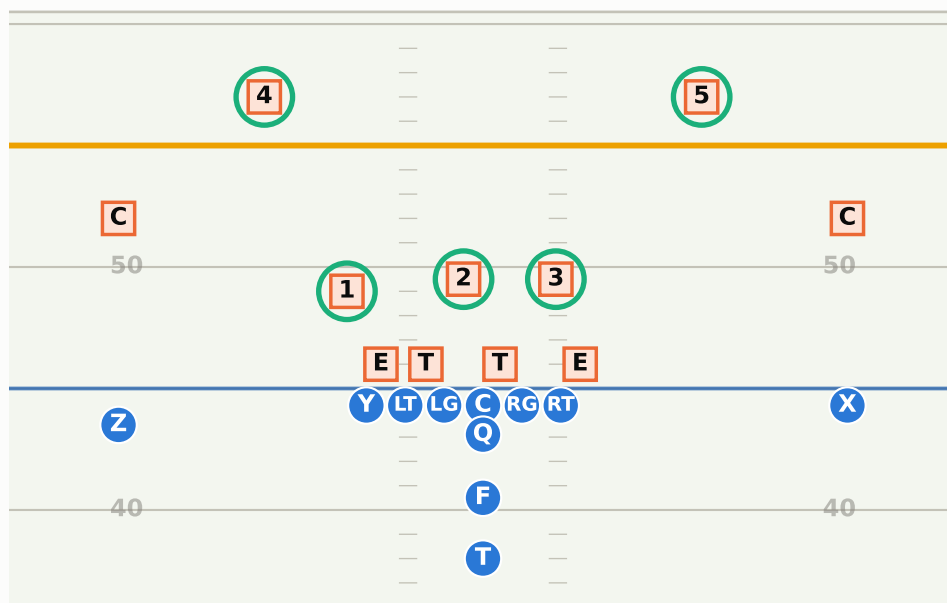


Figure 11: The offense is in the I-formation again, but this time the tight end (Y) is on the offense's left. The defense is in its base 4-3. The three linebackers are numbered 1, 2, 3 and the two safeties 4 and 5.

Which of 1, 2 and 3 is the Mike, the Sam and the Will? Which of 4 and 5 is the strong safety? And which side of the field would you expect a defensive coordinator to worry about for the run?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: count the defenders

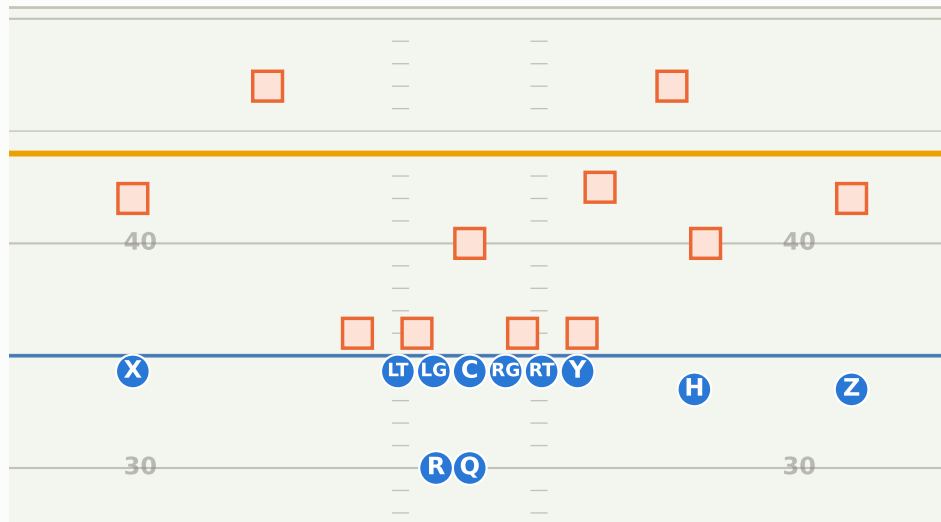


Figure 12: Third-and-9. The offense has three receivers to the right and one to the left. The defenders are unlabeled on purpose: identify them by where they stand.

How many defensive linemen, linebackers and defensive backs are on the field? What does that tell you about what the defense expects, and which defensive player has left the field compared with the base defense?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: who may catch it?

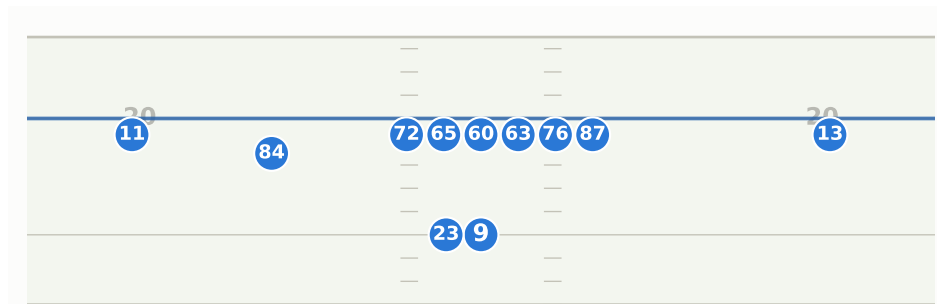


Figure 13: The quarterback (9) is in the shotgun, with the running back (23) beside him. Count who is on the line of scrimmage: the receivers 11 and 13 are on the line, 84 is a yard off it, and the tight end 87 is on the line next to the right tackle.

Which players may catch a forward pass on this play? The tight end, 87, catches one ten yards downfield. Will there be a flag?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- Football has **three teams on one roster**: offense, defense, special teams. Unlimited substitution (permanent in the NFL since 1950) let each player specialize, which is why bodies now match jobs so closely.
- Offense**: five **linemen** (center, guards, tackles) who block and may not catch passes; a **quarterback**; one or two **backs** (running back, sometimes a fullback); and pass-catchers split between **wide receivers** (X, Z, slot) and the **tight end**, who is half blocker and half receiver, and whose side names the strong side.

- **Eligibility is a rule about alignment:** seven on the line, only the two ends and the backs may catch a pass (not a quarterback under center), and jersey numbers 50–79 mark the ineligible linemen.
- **Defense:** a **front seven** of linemen (tackles, nose, ends/**edge rushers**) and linebackers (**Mike**, **Sam** on the tight end side, **Will** away from it), and a **secondary** of cornerbacks, safeties and, in the modern default, a **slot cornerback**. The closer a defender stands to the ball, the more he’s built for the run.
- **Special teams** have their own specialists: kicker, punter, long snapper, holder, returner, gunner.
- **Position, alignment, assignment** are three different things: who he is, where he stands, what he does. Reading the game means using alignment to guess assignment, and the best players (and coaches) blur the three on purpose.

Connections

Builds on: The Game in Fifteen Minutes (the field, the kicking plays and how points are scored).

Sets up: What a Play Really Is follows one call from the coach to these twenty-two players. Personnel turns “one back, one tight end” into the “11” you’ll see on every broadcast graphic, and A First Look at Defense names the defensive packages (base, nickel, dime) and the box. Every position gets its own deeper treatment later: Formation Rules (receivers’ letters, covered receivers, reporting eligible), Pass Protection (the line), Quarterback Play, Defensive Line Play, Linebackers, Coverage Fundamentals (the secondary), The Pass Rush (edge rushers) and Field Goals, Extra Points, and the Punting Game (the specialists). Why some positions cost so much more than others is in Building a Roster.

Case studies: the fullback and the “wide back” are at the heart of Shanahan’s Wide-Zone Tree; the modern safety who plays everywhere returns in From Two-High to Macdonald.

Go deeper

- Pat Kirwan, *Take Your Eye Off the Ball* (2010; 2nd ed. 2015): a former NFL coach and scout teaches fans to watch the players away from the ball, position by position. The best next read after this chapter.
- Michael Lewis, *The Blind Side* (2006): the left tackle, the edge rusher and the economics that tied them together.
- The NFL’s official rulebook (operations.nfl.com), Rules 5 (players and numbering), 7 (formations) and 8 (the forward pass and eligibility): surprisingly readable.
- nflverse’s combine data (`load_combine()` in `nflreadpy`): every measurement in this chapter’s chart, ready to explore by position or school.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

1 is the Sam, 2 is the Mike, 3 is the Will; 4 is the strong safety. The names come from the tight end. He’s on the offense’s left (your left as you look at the picture), so that’s the strong side: the Sam (1) lines up there, across from the tight end, ready to take on his block, and the strong safety (4) sits deep on that side. The Mike (2) is in the middle, and the Will (3) is on the weak side, away from the tight end, where there are fewer blockers.

The run worry is the strong side. The tight end gives the offense an extra blocker on the left, so more gaps to fill there; that’s exactly why the defense puts its biggest linebacker and its run-support safety on that side. If the tight end flipped to the right before the snap, all of those names would flip with him. Watching the Sam move when the tight end moves is one of the first live “reads” you can make.

Answer 2.

Four linemen, one linebacker, six defensive backs. The four squares on the line are the defensive linemen. Only one defender stands alone in the middle at linebacker depth. The other six are defensive backs: a cornerback on each outside receiver, a slot cornerback over the inside slot receiver, a sixth defensive back a little deeper over the tight end side, and two safeties deep.

Six defensive backs is called **dime** (two nickels, so to speak), a package taught in A First Look at Defense. Compared with the base 4-3, **two linebackers have left**, almost certainly the Sam and one of the others, replaced by two extra defensive backs. The defense is telling you it expects a pass: on third-and-9 the offense needs nine yards, a run rarely gets that, and the defense wants as many fast cover players on the field as it can afford. The price is that only five defenders (four linemen and one linebacker) are near the ball, so a draw or a quarterback run is the offense’s natural counter, and you’ll see it on third-and-long more than you’d expect.

Answer 3.

Eligible: 11, 13, 84, 23 and the quarterback, 9. Not eligible: the five linemen and the tight end, 87. Yes, a flag.

Count the line. Eight players are on it: 11, the five linemen, 87 and 13. (Eight is legal; the rule is *at least* seven.) Only the two ends of that line are eligible, and the ends are 11 on the left and **13 on the right**, because 13 is lined up on the line *outside* the tight end. That “covers” 87: he’s on the line but not at the end of it, so on this play he’s an ineligible receiver despite being a tight end with an eligible number. The officials will throw a flag: an ineligible player may not catch a forward pass (and, ten yards downfield, he was also well past the one yard an ineligible player is allowed). The penalties themselves are in Contact Rules and Penalties; the catch itself is *illegal touching of a forward pass*, a 5-yard foul.²⁷

The backs are 84 (a yard off the line), 23, and the quarterback. **The quarterback is eligible here**, because he’s in the shotgun rather than taking a hand-to-hand snap under center, so he counts as a back. Teams do occasionally throw back to a shotgun quarterback on trick plays.

This is why the rules care so much about a one-yard step. Move 13 off the line, and 87 becomes the end and eligible again. Offenses use exactly this kind of adjustment to change who’s eligible, and the defense has to notice. More in Formation Rules and the Language of Alignment.

²⁷NFL Rule 8, Section 1, Article 8; the penalty summary lists “Illegal touching of a forward pass” among the 5-yard fouls, separately from the loss-of-down fouls. NFL.com, “2025 rulebook, part 2”: <https://www.nfl.com/news/2025-rulebook-part-2>